

c. 1945, October 4

The following is a faithful transcription of the typewritten autograph by the Servant of God. Father Solanus Casey, O.F.M.Cap.

(written perhaps to Edwin Wilhite)

On the face of a picture of himself, he has written:

How like autumn flowers, bleaches the freshness of youth;
and ideals change like raiments of the soul!

Fr. Solanus

On the back of the picture, he has typed:

Oct. 4th. Feast of St. Francis of Assissi

Bles'd be God in all and each of his designs!

My Dear Nephew Edwin:

May God bless you and give you holy resignation and, of course the crown ineffable that must follow, if perfect. Even in this side of the grave astonishments come as for such Christian virtue.

A certain over-grown John Joseph M., a contemporary of your great-grand-father, a namesake and probably a relative, skipped school at 13 because ashamed to go to class with little boys; joined the British navy, went to the far East; later failed in an enterprise in London, joined the Hudson-Bay Co., joined an Indian tribe and became the famous "Chief Black Eagle of the North." Very charitable to the poor Indians whom, from the beginning he had learned to love, he was called to something greater.

Deep in the wilderness he came across a sort of little clearing and there in the crutch of a big tree met a weather-beaten statue of our Immaculate Mother.....Calling his braves together shortly thereafter he resigned, disposed of his vast estates, went to Rome and five Yrs. later was ordained a priest; returned to Ireland and after several years mission in London became the famous Father John of Cork....Who does not get a taste of the Cross one way or other and, if only with resignation: "The bigger the cross the greater the crown."

Fr. Solanus, O.F.M.Cap.